NOTES OF CAUTION

- Though superior in manpower and hardware, India has a full military commitment on its China border, blunting the edge over Pakistan
- China will extend full support to Pakistan in electronic warfare, intelligence, spares and ammunition
- India has numerical superiority when it comes to land, air and sea platforms, but it has to leverage them effectively
- Pakistan is strong in asymmetric/drone warfare and has also acquired new assets from Turkey



WITH ITS MUSCULAR RESPONSE, INDIA HAS SENT OUT A STRONG MESSAGE THAT IT WILL HAVE ZERO TOLERANCE FOR TERROR

populous provinces—Punjab and Sindh—rely on three of these rivers for drinking water supply and agriculture.

The Pakistani Response

The sheer scale of India's military strikes stunned Pakistan, who called it another act of war. Pakistani prime minister Shehbaz Sharif took to X on May 7, warning, "Pakistan reserves the absolute right to respond decisively to this unprovoked Indian act—a resolute response is already under way.... The enemy will never be allowed to achieve its malicious aims." Later that night, Pakistan launched a series of drone and missile attacks across India's northern and western border spanning Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab, Rajasthan and even Gujarat. India upped the ante by targeting Pakistan's air defence radar and systems in several locations, including in Lahore, demonstrating that its prime city, too, was vulnerable to Indian aerial strikes. Pakistan, in turn, used drones and missile to target military stations in Jammu, Pathankot and Udhampur, along the international border in J&K. India, meanwhile, reportedly launched a missile strike on a Pakistani naval base which, if true, would be the first time it has done so since 1971.

The rapid escalation of hostilities is pushing India and Pakistan into a war neither country really wants or can afford. Pakistan's economy is in dire straits, saved from a

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY